

# The GLP-1 Muscle Cheat Sheet

Keep your muscle while you lose the weight. The numbers that matter, on one page.

## 1 The problem

Up to ~40% of the weight you lose on a GLP-1 can be lean mass, not fat. Reviews of the trial data put lean mass at roughly 15-40% of total loss; the SURMOUNT-1 DXA substudy measured about a quarter of tirzepatide weight loss as lean mass. The scale can't tell you.

## 2 Hit your protein target

Aim for 1.6-2.2 g of protein per kg of bodyweight per day - about double the 0.8 g/kg RDA. The hard part on a suppressed appetite is hitting it: use several small, protein-forward 'meals' (Greek yogurt, shakes, cottage cheese, lean meat) and front-load protein early.

## 3 Train for muscle, not just movement

Resistance training 2-3x/week, taking sets close to failure, adding reps or load over time. A 2023 meta-analysis found no meaningful muscle-growth difference between free weights and machines - the same logic covers bands and bodyweight. Progressive overload is the signal.

## 4 Creatine (optional, cheap, well-studied)

~3-5 g/day. The kidney worry is largely a myth in healthy people. Expect a small early scale bump from water in the muscle - that is not fat. It supports training in a deficit.

## 5 Plan the off-ramp before you need it

Without a plan, a large share of lost weight can return within a year. Muscle you build now means a higher resting metabolism later. Taper with a real maintenance protocol, not cold.

### Want the full, fully-cited playbook?

The complete handbook + companion guides walk through every protocol above with linked studies.

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